relations with India have been quite cordial even before independence and I think they will go on improving after independence. India has had a fairly wide experience of the problems which face us today and, when I visited India, I found our little problems there magnified to cinemascope size which made them more easy to understand.

According to a R&AW officer who had attended the meeting, after Gandhi read the note, he said, 'Ratu Mara was sowing the seed of enmity between Indians and Fijians. The coup did not take place now. In fact, Ratu Mara prepared the ground for a person like Rabuka to strike whenever Indians gained leverage in Fiji politics.'

Shekhawat told me that Mara was completely sold on the Americans and the British and hated the Indians. On the other hand, the Indian government had a very strong emotional connect with the Fiji Indians and they did not want it to be overpowered by diplomatic complexities engendered by the enhanced cultural and trade cooperation between Fiji and its neighbours, Australia and New Zealand.

'We wanted Indianness to survive in Fiji,' said Shekhawat. 'So, while Australia and New Zealand investors rushed to Fiji to invest in different sectors of the economy, the Indian government decided to install strong and permanent business enterprises.'

The intention of the Australian and New Zealand investors in the 1970s was to maintain control over the domestic Fiji market which they had ruled for the past many decades. As far as the India-Australia relationship was concerned, the two countries had a number of things in common—both were members of the British Commonwealth of Nations, enjoyed a parliamentary